

Diversity Statement

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Diversity, equity, inclusion and belonging are significant beliefs that I carry in and outside of my classroom. These four values are important in a world that often sets certain standards that encourage individuals to fit in one category. Humans are not monolithic and it is important that I as a theater educator demonstrate that art is diverse by providing various forms of theatrical scripts that show and elevate different cultures, backgrounds, and risk-taking. Highlighting diversity in a theatrical space is essential because art is diverse and therefore so is the creator of the art. In a theater classroom, students are creating every single day through performances, script writing, and character development. They need to be allowed a space where they can showcase their art while also encouraging students to try different techniques through positive and effective feedback. Theater is vulnerable and requires constant encouragement for students and their choices in the things they choose to create. I believe that in order for my classroom to be diverse and equitable I must offer the resources needed to help my students succeed. I understand that each of my students have various learning styles, come from different backgrounds, and lead in various ways. I must welcome, show, and hold expectations in my class that elevate my students and their diverse personalities and backgrounds.

As an educator I have to constantly reflect on the power, privilege and access I have. I acknowledge that I have authority in the classroom but I also have to ensure my students have a voice in the classroom through expectations we hold each other to and personal choices when presenting work. I also have to ensure that all students are seen by recognizing their individualism, their cultures and how it shapes my lesson planning. As a Mexican individual who once was in high school and college, I felt underrepresented in the curriculum my educators provided us. I never felt represented in class and my identity amongst others in my class went

unknown or unspoken. I never want my students to feel the same way I did. My students deserve to feel seen in class through the content provided to them. I also will make sure that aside from my lesson planning and materials representing my students, that I will also learn how to pronounce my students' names. Everyone's identity is connected to their name. My name has always been mispronounced and my teachers never strived to learn it. As educators we always have to learn and not striving to learn our students' names and their pronunciations is unacceptable to anyone. Educators aren't perfect but they are to make sure their students feel a sense of belonging and inclusion and with that comes the learning of their identities and names.

As a teacher I have to take steps in my classroom to support inclusive and affirming theater spaces. Through intensive curriculum planning, I will ensure that the content I provide is inclusive and diverse for all learners and that every individual feels and is represented in the curriculum. I will also provide various pedagogical teaching and learning approaches for students and will provide lessons and assignments that are accessible to all students. Creating classroom norms are also essential in making sure that my classroom is diverse, equitable, and inclusive for all of my students. I will have students provide me with class expectations and create a classroom expectation contract in which they all agree on the expectations they have provided. I will also aim to foster trauma informed practices such as building relationships with students, having structured support, and modeling empathy to students. I will also include social, emotional learning practices in my curriculum and daily activities. While having these practices is essential for a class, it is important to acknowledge that this work is continuously developing through constant experiences with students and individuals. Each student and person I interact with has different needs and no class is the same. I have to continuously learn new approaches

and grow from daily interactions. Learning is continuous and never ending but so is applying and changing classroom strategies.